

Panic sets in

On April 28, two US Marine corporals at Tan Son Nhut, Charles MacMahon and Darwin Judge, were killed during a bombardment. They were the last Americans killed in the Vietnam War. The next day, Ambassador Martin at last accepted that fixed-wing flights were no longer possible and authorized implementation of a backup plan, codenamed Frequent Wind, for final evacuation by helicopter. US Navy carriers were in position off the Vietnamese coast to carry out the plan. After gathering at assembly points in response to a signal—the playing of the song “White Christmas” on the radio—most evacuees were bussed to the Defense Attaché Office compound. A subsidiary evacuation was arranged from the US Embassy building. US Marines were used to provide security, which was very much needed as desperate Vietnamese flocked to the evacuation sites.

Flying back and forth between Saigon and the fleet, helicopter crews acted with outstanding skill and efficiency under trying conditions. Flight decks were disrupted by the arrival of fleeing Vietnamese in their own helicopters or fixed-wing aircraft. Parked helicopters had to be ditched overboard to make space for new arrivals to land. At the same time as the airborne evacuation, more than 40,000 fleeing Vietnamese escaped by sea to join private or naval vessels.

By the early hours of April 30, the only remaining evacuation point was a helipad on the roof of the US Embassy. Ambassador Martin was among the last to be flown out as panic-stricken Vietnamese stormed the embassy building, desperate to escape the city. A few hours after the final helicopter left the embassy’s roof, North Vietnamese tanks reached the presidential palace in the heart of Saigon.



Any way out

Evacuees board a CIA Air America helicopter from an improvised helipad on an apartment building in Saigon. Taken by Dutch photojournalist Hubert van Es, this became the iconic image of the evacuation.